JanGyan — Learn Without Limits

Category 6: Environment & Civic Responsibility

Module 9 – Green Lifestyle & Sustainable Living

Module Overview

This handbook is your complete, beginner-to-advanced guide to **Green Lifestyle & Sustainable Living** — what it means to live sustainably, how India's own Mission LiFE translates this into everyday action, and the practical habits every household can adopt. Whether you are a student, a homemaker, a working professional, or a civic volunteer, this handbook is written so you can read it once and walk away confident and capable.

By the end of this module, you will not need to search anywhere else to understand the fundamentals of sustainable living in India.

Learning Objectives

After completing this module, you will be able to:

- Define sustainable living and explain its three core pillars
- Understand India's Mission LiFE and its guiding principles
- Apply eco-friendly habits across shopping, transport, and home life
- Reduce single-use plastic dependency in daily routines
- Understand what makes a building or a city genuinely “green”
- Calculate and reduce your personal carbon footprint
- Recognise the government bodies and programmes supporting sustainable living in India
- Apply a practical daily checklist for sustainable choices

Why This Topic Matters

Sustainable living is often framed as a modern, aspirational idea — but for most of Indian history, resource-conscious living was simply how life was lived. Reusing, repairing, sharing, and minimising waste were embedded in everyday culture long before “sustainability” became a global buzzword.

> ***Reality Check:*** *India's per capita carbon footprint remains about 60% lower than the global average, a legacy in part of traditional, resource-conscious lifestyle practices (Mission LiFE, MoEFCC). India launched Mission LiFE — Lifestyle for Environment — at the Statue of Unity on 20 October 2022, aiming to build a global movement of ‘Pro-Planet People’ committed to mindful, sustainable daily choices rather than wasteful consumption.*

Yet rising incomes, urbanisation, and changing consumption patterns are steadily pushing India's per capita footprint upward. Sustainable living, at its core, is about deliberately choosing to keep the benefits of modern life without repeating the resource-intensive mistakes of other rapidly industrialised economies.

This is why JanGyan continues its Environment & Civic Responsibility category with this essential module.

Introduction

Sustainable living means making lifestyle choices that reduce one's environmental impact — conserving resources, minimising waste, and supporting practices that maintain ecological balance for the long term. A **green lifestyle** is the everyday, practical expression of sustainable living, covering what we buy, how we travel, and how we treat the resources we consume.

In simple words: sustainable living is choosing options today that do not compromise what future generations will have available tomorrow — whether that is clean water, breathable air, or a stable climate.

India's own approach to this, formalised through Mission LiFE, deliberately draws on traditional values of conservation and moderation, framing sustainability not as an imported concept but as a return to practices already embedded in Indian culture.

Fundamental Concepts

Before going deeper, let us understand a few foundational ideas that the entire subject of sustainable living is built upon.

The Three Pillars of Mission LiFE

Mission LiFE, launched in October 2022, organises sustainable individual action into three broad pillars.

Pillar	Focus
Individual as a Consumer	Making mindful, low-waste choices in daily consumption habits
Individual as a Community Member	Encouraging collective, local-level sustainable action
Individual as a Practitioner	Applying sustainable practices in one's own profession or workplace

Key Definitions

- **Carbon Footprint** — The total greenhouse gases generated, directly or indirectly, by an individual, product, or activity.
- **Green Building** — A structure designed to minimise environmental impact through energy-efficient design, sustainable materials, and resource-conscious operation.
- **Circular Economy** — An economic model that minimises waste by keeping resources in use through reuse, repair, and recycling.
- **Responsible Consumption** — Purchasing decisions made with awareness of their environmental and social impact.
- **Pro-Planet People** — Mission LiFE's term for individuals committed to adopting and promoting environment-friendly lifestyles.

Complete Detailed Explanation

Part A — Mission LiFE, In Depth

The concept of LiFE (Lifestyle for Environment) was introduced by India's Prime Minister at COP26 in Glasgow in 2021 and officially launched on 20 October 2022 at the Statue of Unity, Gujarat, in the presence of the UN Secretary-General. It promotes specific, practical actions: saving energy at home, choosing cycling, electric vehicles, or public transport over private driving, avoiding unnecessary flights, eating more plant-based food, and reducing food waste.

The mission also introduced the Green Credit Programme in October 2023, a market-based mechanism that rewards individuals, industries, and institutions for voluntary environmental actions across eight categories, including tree plantation, water conservation, sustainable agriculture, and sustainable building and infrastructure.

Part B — The Ten Building Blocks of Module 9

This is the heart of the module. Each topic below is explained with its core meaning and its practical relevance for Indian households.

1. Sustainable Living

Sustainable living means making lifestyle choices that reduce one's environmental impact — conserving resources, minimising waste, and supporting practices that maintain ecological balance for the long term.

2. Eco-Friendly Habits

Simple daily habits — carrying reusable bags, choosing energy-efficient products, minimising food waste, and conserving water and electricity — collectively reduce environmental strain when adopted widely.

3. Plastic-Free Lifestyle

Reducing single-use plastic by choosing reusable bottles, cloth bags, steel or glass containers, and biodegradable alternatives helps cut plastic pollution in landfills, rivers, and oceans.

4. Sustainable Transportation

Choosing walking, cycling, public transport, carpooling, or electric vehicles over private fuel-powered vehicles reduces carbon emissions, traffic congestion, and air pollution.

5. Green Buildings

Green buildings are designed to minimise environmental impact through energy-efficient design, sustainable materials, rainwater harvesting, and natural lighting; India now ranks third globally in LEED-certified green buildings.

6. Sustainable Shopping

Sustainable shopping involves choosing products with minimal packaging, supporting local and ethical producers, buying only what is needed, and favouring durable, repairable goods over disposable ones.

7. Responsible Consumption

Responsible consumption means being mindful of what and how much we consume — avoiding overconsumption, reducing food waste, and considering the environmental and social footprint of purchasing decisions.

8. Carbon Footprint Reduction

Reducing one's carbon footprint involves conserving energy, choosing sustainable transport, eating more plant-based meals, reducing waste, and supporting renewable energy sources.

9. Smart City Concepts

Smart cities integrate technology and sustainable planning — efficient public transport, smart grids, waste management systems, and green infrastructure — to improve quality of life while reducing environmental impact.

10. Daily Sustainable Practices

Small, consistent daily actions — carrying reusables, segregating waste, choosing efficient transport, supporting local produce — are what turn Mission LiFE's national vision into measurable household-level impact.

Important Terminologies

Term	Simple Meaning
Carbon Footprint	Total greenhouse gases generated by a person, product, or activity
Circular Economy	An economic model minimising waste by keeping resources in use through reuse and recycling
Green Building	A structure designed to minimise environmental impact through efficient design and materials
Green Credit Programme	A market-based scheme rewarding voluntary environmental actions across eight categories
GRIHA / IGBC / LEED	Green building certification systems assessing environmental performance
Mission LiFE	India's national movement promoting mindful, sustainable individual lifestyle choices
Pro-Planet People	Mission LiFE's term for individuals committed to sustainable lifestyle practices
Responsible Consumption	Purchasing decisions made with awareness of environmental and social impact
Single-Use Plastic	Plastic items designed to be used only once before disposal
Smart City	An urban area using technology and planning to improve efficiency, sustainability, and quality of life

Step-by-Step Understanding

How to Calculate and Reduce Your Carbon Footprint

1. Assess — Use an online carbon footprint calculator to estimate emissions from home energy, travel, and diet

2. Identify — Pinpoint your largest contributing categories (often transport or energy use)

3. Reduce — Apply targeted changes, such as switching to public transport or energy-efficient appliances

4. Offset (where relevant) — Support verified afforestation or renewable energy projects for unavoidable emissions

5. Track — Reassess periodically to measure progress and identify new opportunities

How to Build a Plastic-Free Daily Routine

1. Carry a reusable bag, bottle, and cutlery set when going out

2. Choose loose produce over pre-packaged plastic-wrapped items where possible

3. Store food in steel or glass containers instead of single-use plastic

4. Say no to plastic straws, cutlery, and carry bags at point of purchase

5. Choose refill options for household cleaning and personal care products where available

6. Segregate and responsibly dispose of any unavoidable plastic waste

Real-Life Indian Examples

(Widely known public examples, described for educational awareness.)

- **Mission LiFE's Global Launch:** Officially launched on 20 October 2022 at the Statue of Unity, Gujarat, in the presence of UN Secretary-General António Guterres, positioning India as a global leader in behaviour-driven climate action.
- **India's G20 Presidency (2023):** India integrated Mission LiFE into its G20 agenda under the theme 'One Earth, One Family, One Future,' building international momentum for sustainable lifestyles.
- **The Green Credit Programme:** Launched in October 2023, this market-based mechanism rewards individuals, societies, and companies for voluntary actions across eight categories, including tree plantation and sustainable building.
- **India's Green Building Growth:** India now ranks third globally in LEED-certified buildings, with government programmes like the Smart Cities Mission and PMAY offering tax benefits and low-interest loans for certified green developments.

Practical Scenarios

Scenario 1: You are grocery shopping and notice most produce is wrapped in single-use plastic.

Choose loose fruits and vegetables where available, bring your own reusable produce bags, and support vendors who offer plastic-free packaging options.

Scenario 2: You are planning a home renovation and want it to be more sustainable.

Consider energy-efficient lighting, water-saving fixtures, natural ventilation improvements, and materials with recognised green certifications like GRIHA or IGBC.

Scenario 3: Your daily commute currently relies entirely on a private vehicle.

Explore whether public transport, carpooling, or a partial shift to cycling or walking is feasible for at least part of your regular commute.

Government Rules / Guidelines

- **Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC):** Leads Mission LiFE and the Green Credit Programme, coordinating India's sustainable lifestyle policy.
- **Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA):** Drives the Smart Cities Mission and supports green building adoption through urban planning incentives.
- **Indian Green Building Council (IGBC) & GRIHA Council:** India's leading green building certification bodies, assessing environmental performance of construction projects.
- **Bureau of Energy Efficiency (BEE):** Supports energy-efficient appliance labelling that underpins sustainable household choices.

Laws & Policies

Law / Policy	What It Covers
Mission LiFE (Lifestyle for Environment), 2022	India's national movement promoting mindful, sustainable individual lifestyle choices
Green Credit Programme, 2023	A market-based scheme rewarding voluntary environmental actions across eight categories
Plastic Waste Management Amendment Rules, 2021/2022	Bans identified single-use plastic items, supporting plastic-free lifestyle adoption
Smart Cities Mission	Promotes efficient, sustainable urban infrastructure and planning
Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana (PMAY)	Offers incentives supporting sustainable, certified-green housing development
India's NDC under the Paris Agreement	Frames national sustainability targets that individual lifestyle choices contribute toward

> *Mission LiFE was first proposed by India's Prime Minister at COP26 in Glasgow in 2021 and officially launched on 20 October 2022, positioning individual behavioural change as a core pillar of India's climate strategy, alongside policy and technology.*

Important Statistics

Metric	Figure
India's per capita carbon footprint vs global average	About 60% lower than the global average (Mission LiFE, MoEFCC)
Mission LiFE official launch date	20 October 2022, at the Statue of Unity, Gujarat
Green Credit Programme launch date	13 October 2023
Categories covered under the Green Credit Programme	8 (including tree plantation, water, sustainable agriculture, waste management, air pollution reduction, mangrove conservation, eco mark, and sustainable buildings)
India's global rank in LEED-certified buildings	3rd worldwide
Mission LiFE's three pillars	Individual as Consumer, Community Member, and Practitioner

(Figures sourced from the official Mission LiFE portal (Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change) and Green Credit Programme documentation; official portals should be checked for the latest updates.)

Best Practices

- Carry reusable bags, bottles, and containers as a daily habit
- Choose public transport, carpooling, cycling, or walking wherever feasible
- Buy only what you need, favouring durable and repairable goods
- Reduce food waste through mindful meal planning
- Choose energy-efficient appliances and lighting
- Support local, seasonal, and sustainably produced goods

Common Mistakes

- Treating sustainable living as an expensive or inconvenient lifestyle choice
- Relying on single-use plastic out of habit or convenience
- Overlooking food waste as a significant contributor to environmental impact
- Assuming sustainability applies only to large purchases, not daily habits
- Ignoring the cumulative impact of small, repeated unsustainable choices

Myths vs Facts

Myth	Fact
"Sustainable living is a modern, Western import unsuited to Indian life"	Mission LiFE explicitly draws on traditional Indian values of conservation and moderation already embedded in cultural practice
"Green products and buildings are always significantly more expensive"	Government incentives, tax benefits, and long-term energy savings often offset or outweigh the upfront cost difference
"Individual lifestyle choices are irrelevant next to industrial emissions"	Mission LiFE positions individual behavioural change as a core, complementary pillar alongside policy and industrial action
"Reducing plastic use is only about avoiding bags"	It extends to packaging, containers, personal care products, and everyday purchasing decisions across many categories

Do's and Don'ts

Do	Don't
Carry reusable bags, bottles, and containers	Don't default to single-use plastic out of convenience
Choose sustainable transport where feasible	Don't rely solely on private vehicles for every trip
Buy only what you need and use it fully	Don't overconsume or overbuy disposable goods
Choose energy-efficient appliances	Don't ignore energy ratings when purchasing
Support local, sustainably produced goods	Don't assume sustainability only matters for big purchases

Practical Tips

For Households

Keep reusable bags near the door for shopping trips • Store food in steel or glass rather than plastic • Plan meals to reduce food waste

For Communities

Organise plastic-free market or vendor initiatives • Encourage shared, sustainable transport options • Support local green building and eco-development projects

For Schools & Workplaces

Introduce Mission LiFE awareness sessions • Set up refill or reuse stations for common supplies • Encourage carpooling or public transport for commutes

Practical Checklist

■	I carry reusable bags, bottles, or containers when going out
■	I choose public transport, carpooling, or cycling for at least some trips
■	I plan meals to reduce food waste at home
■	I check energy ratings before buying new appliances
■	I know at least one green building certification (GRIHA, IGBC, or LEED)
■	I have calculated or estimated my personal carbon footprint
■	I have discussed sustainable living habits with family or peers

Quick Revision Notes

- Sustainable living = choices that reduce environmental impact while meeting present needs
- Mission LiFE (launched 20 October 2022) organises action around three pillars: consumer, community member, practitioner
- India's per capita carbon footprint is about 60% below the global average
- The Green Credit Programme (2023) rewards voluntary environmental action across 8 categories
- India ranks 3rd globally in LEED-certified green buildings
- MoEFCC and MoHUA are India's key sustainable-living and green-building policy bodies

Key Takeaways

1. Sustainable living is rooted in traditional Indian practice, not an entirely new import

2. Mission LiFE positions individual behaviour as complementary to, not a substitute for, policy and industrial climate action

3. Small, consistent daily choices — plastic reduction, transport, consumption — add up to measurable collective impact

4. Government incentives increasingly make sustainable choices, from appliances to housing, more financially accessible

5. A green lifestyle is achievable at any income level, through mindful consumption rather than expensive purchases alone

Glossary

- **Carbon Footprint** — Total greenhouse gases generated by a person, product, or activity
- **Circular Economy** — An economic model minimising waste by keeping resources in use through reuse and recycling
- **Green Building** — A structure designed to minimise environmental impact through efficient design and materials
- **Green Credit Programme** — A market-based scheme rewarding voluntary environmental actions
- **GRIHA / IGBC / LEED** — Green building certification systems
- **Mission LiFE** — India's national movement promoting sustainable individual lifestyle choices
- **Pro-Planet People** — Mission LiFE's term for individuals committed to sustainable lifestyle practices
- **Responsible Consumption** — Purchasing decisions made with awareness of environmental and social impact
- **Single-Use Plastic** — Plastic items designed to be used only once before disposal
- **Smart City** — An urban area using technology and planning to improve sustainability and quality of life

Frequently Asked Questions

1. What is Mission LiFE?
India's national movement, Lifestyle for Environment, launched on 20 October 2022, promoting mindful, sustainable individual lifestyle choices as a pillar of climate action.

2. What are the three pillars of Mission LiFE?
Individual as a Consumer, Individual as a Community Member, and Individual as a Practitioner.

3. How does India's carbon footprint compare globally?
India's per capita carbon footprint is about 60% lower than the global average, reflecting traditional, resource-conscious lifestyle practices.

4. What is the Green Credit Programme?
A market-based scheme launched in October 2023 that rewards individuals, societies, and companies for voluntary environmental actions across eight categories.

5. What makes a building 'green'?
Green buildings are designed to minimise environmental impact through energy-efficient design, sustainable materials, water conservation, and natural lighting and ventilation.

6. Which certifications indicate a green building in India?
GRIHA and IGBC are India's own green building rating systems, alongside the internationally recognised LEED certification.

7. Is sustainable living necessarily expensive?
Not inherently — many sustainable habits (reducing waste, using public transport, buying only what is needed) actually reduce costs over time.

8. How can I reduce single-use plastic in daily life?
Carry reusable bags, bottles, and containers; choose loose produce and refill options; and avoid plastic cutlery and straws at the point of purchase.

9. What is a smart city, in the Indian context?
An urban area that integrates technology and sustainable planning — efficient transport, smart grids, and green infrastructure — to improve liveability while reducing environmental impact.

10. How do I calculate my personal carbon footprint?

Use an online carbon footprint calculator that accounts for home energy use, transportation habits, and diet to estimate your total greenhouse gas impact.

Official References

- Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC) — official Mission LiFE portal
- Green Credit Programme official documentation, 2023
- Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA) — Smart Cities Mission and PMAY programme information
- Indian Green Building Council (IGBC) and GRIHA Council — green building certification standards
- Plastic Waste Management Amendment Rules, 2021/2022 — India Code portal

Official Government Website Links

- Mission LiFE: **https://missionlife-moefcc.nic.in**
- Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change: **https://moefcc.gov.in**
- Smart Cities Mission: **https://smartcities.gov.in**
- Indian Green Building Council: **https://igbc.in**
- Press Information Bureau: **https://pib.gov.in**

Conclusion

A green lifestyle is not about giving up modern convenience — it is about choosing it more mindfully. From the reusable bag in your hand to the appliance rating on your refrigerator, every small choice adds to a pattern that, multiplied across a household, a community, and a nation, shapes India's environmental future. Mission LiFE reminds us that this way of living is not new to India — it is a return to habits already within reach.

Continue your Environment & Civic Responsibility journey with JanGyan. Stay mindful, stay consistent, and remember: sustainable living begins with the choices in front of you today.

JanGyan — Learn Without Limits
Module 9 of the Environment & Civic Responsibility Category